



5 questions before an argument

What to ask yourself before reacting, so you don't repeat the same fight.

VIVIANNE DOS SANTOS

*This guide is a self-knowledge
resource about relationships. It does
not replace couples therapy.*

1. The reaction that ruins everything

You know what the moment is. The moment when he says that thing (or doesn't say it, because sometimes silence is the trigger) and something inside you ignites. It's not a thought. It's a wave. A heat that rises, a tightening in the chest, an almost uncontrollable urge to react. To respond. To attack. To defend yourself. To make him feel what you're feeling.

And you react. The same way you reacted last time. With the same words, the same tone, the same venom. And while you're speaking, a part of you knows you shouldn't be saying that. A part of you sees itself from outside and thinks: "Not again." But it can't stop. Because the reaction is faster than consciousness. The body already moved before the mind had time to think.

And then the after comes. The icy silence. Or the door slamming. Or the tears. Or the night staring at the ceiling without talking. Or the hurried reconciliation that resolves the surface but doesn't touch the depth. And both of them know this will happen again. Because it always does.

Almost every couple I know lives trapped in this cycle. The trigger can be different (the dishes, the children, money, sex, the in-laws, the phone), but the mechanism is always the same: stimulus, reaction, regret, repetition. Like a film playing on a loop.

And the worst part is that with each repetition, something wears down. Not just patience: trust. Intimacy. The will to try. Each repeated argument is like sandpaper on the surface of the relationship. The first time, you barely notice. The hundredth time, it's already raw. And many couples only seek help when there's almost nothing left, when the wear is so great that recovering seems impossible.

But it isn't. It's never too late to change a pattern. But it's easier to change it before the sandpaper has worn everything away. And this guide is for now. For the next argument. For the next moment when you feel the impulse rising and, instead of reacting, you try something different.

There is one thing I want you to understand before we go further: I'm not asking you to control yourself. Controlling is repressing. It's swallowing. It's silencing what you feel to keep the peace. That doesn't work. That accumulates and then explodes. What I'm asking is so-

something different: awareness. Not control, awareness. The capacity to feel what you feel and, in that instant, instead of acting automatically, choose how you respond.

And the question that's normally asked is: "How do I change my reaction?" But that is the wrong question. Because trying to change the reaction in the moment it happens is like trying to brake a train that has already left the station. It's already in motion. It already has speed. It's already too late.

The right question is another: "What can I do BEFORE the reaction?" And the answer is: create a space. A space between the stimulus (what he said or did) and your response. A space where you can stop, breathe, and ask yourself what is really happening. Because what is happening, in most cases, is not what it seems.

Viktor Frankl, the psychiatrist who survived Auschwitz, wrote a phrase that changed my life: "Between stimulus and response there is a space. In that space is our power to choose our response. In our response lies our growth and our freedom."

That space is what this guide offers you. Not as theory. As practice. Five questions to ask yourself in that crucial instant between "he said" and "I reacted." Five questions that, if you have the courage to stop and

ask them, can change the outcome of the argument. Not by magic. By awareness.

2. The space between stimulus and response

Before giving you the five questions, I need to tell you about that space. Because if you don't know it exists, you won't look for it.

Most of our reactions in relationships work like this: he says something, you feel something, you react. It seems instantaneous. It seems there's no interval. It seems that the feeling and the reaction are the same thing. But they're not.

Between feeling and reacting there is a fraction of a second. A tiny fraction, almost imperceptible. But it's there. And with practice (not with perfection, with practice), that fraction can widen. It can become half a second. Then one second. Then two. Then enough to breathe. And in that breath, everything changes.

Because when you breathe before reacting, what happens is physiological, not only psychological. Deep breathing activates the vagus nerve, which is the primary regulator of your parasympathetic nervous system. And when the parasympathetic activates, the body moves out of "fight or flight" mode (which is the mode you're in when you feel attacked) and enters "rest and digest" mode. And in that mode, the mind thinks differently. Sees differently. Responds differently.

There is a simple practice that can help widen that space: when you feel the impulse rising, place both hands flat on your thighs (if you're sitting) or on your chest (if you're standing). The physical contact of the hands with the body sends a signal to the nervous system: I am here. I am in my body. I don't need to react right now. It's a small gesture, almost invisible, that no one notices. But it changes what happens inside you.

Another thing that helps: saying mentally "I am feeling" before acting. "I am feeling anger." "I am feeling fear." "I am feeling rejection." The simple act of naming the emotion (as we saw in the guide on emptying your mind) activates the prefrontal cortex and calms the amygdala. It's biology, not mysticism. And it works in seconds.

I'm not saying it's easy. The first time you try to stop in the middle of a wave of rage or pain, your body will protest. It will say: "React! Defend yourself! He's attacking you!" Because the body is trained to react. Decades of patterns don't dissolve with one breath. But they can begin to dissolve. One breath at a time.

And it's in that space, in that pause conquered centimeter by centimeter, that the five questions enter.

3. The 5 questions

You don't need to memorize all of them. You don't need to ask all of them every time. It's enough that, in the moment you feel the urge to react, you ask one. The one that comes to mind. The one you feel is most necessary in that instant.

Question 1: "What am I really feeling?"

Not "what did he do." What am I FEELING. Because in most arguments, we think the problem is what the other person did. But the problem is what we feel in response to what the other person did. And those two things are different.

He didn't put the dishes in the dishwasher. What do you feel? "Anger." No. Go deeper. What do you feel beneath the anger? "That I'm not seen." "That I'm not valued." "That I'm alone in this." "That I do everything and no one notices." There it is. It's not about the dishes. It's about being seen. And when you know what you truly feel, you can communicate that, instead of shouting about the dishes.

"I feel invisible" is infinitely more powerful (and less destructive) than "You never do anything around this house!" Because the first invites understanding. The second invites defensiveness.

And there is something that may surprise you: often, when you name what you truly feel, the other person softens. Because beneath accusation, he hears attack. But beneath vulnerability, he hears truth. And truth, however uncomfortable, disarms. When you say "I feel alone in this," the most likely response is that he goes quiet, breathes, and perhaps says: "I didn't know." And in that "I didn't know," a different conversation begins. Not an argument. A conversation.

Question 2: "Is this about now, or about before?"

This is the most difficult question. And the most transformative. Because often, what you feel now is not about now. It's about before. It's about what your father did. About what your mother didn't do. About an old wound that your partner's gesture reopened without knowing it.

If the intensity of what you feel is disproportionate to the situation (if you're crying over dishes, if you're shouting over a ten-minute delay, if you're devastated by a comment he doesn't even remember making), it's almost certain it's not about now. It's about before. And when you re-

cognize that, something calms. Not because the pain disappears. But because it stops being his fault. And when it stops being his fault, you can talk to him, instead of shout against him.

Question 3: "What do I need in this moment?"

Not what I want him to do. What I need. The difference is enormous. "I want him to apologize" is a demand on the other person. "I need to feel heard" is a truth about me.

When you know what you need, you can ask. And asking is different from demanding. "I need you to listen to me for two minutes without defending yourself" is a request. "You never listen!" is an attack. The result of the attack is defense. The result of the request can be listening.

And if he can't give you what you need in that moment? You can give it to yourself. You can leave the room, breathe, and take care of yourself. Not as punishment ("I'm leaving to punish you"). As care ("I'm going to take care of myself so I can come back whole").

Question 4: "Am I reacting to him, or to my father (my mother, my past)?"

This question comes directly from Family Constellations and is perhaps the most revealing of all. Because often, the person in front of you is not the person making you react. They are a stand-in. A substitute. Your partner says something with a certain tone of voice, and what your body hears is not his voice. It's your father's voice. Or your mother's. Or someone who hurt you a long time ago and whose wound was never treated.

When your partner goes quiet, you're not seeing him. You're seeing the father who was absent. When he raises his voice, you're not hearing him. You're hearing the mother who shouted. And you react as you reacted as a child: with the same fear, the same anger, the same powerlessness.

Recognizing this in the moment is difficult. But when you manage it (and with practice, you manage it more and more), something changes radically. Because you stop fighting with your partner and start taking care of your inner child. And that shift in focus transforms everything.

Question 5: "How do I want to look back on this tomorrow?"

This question takes you out of the heat of the moment and places you in the following day. Because in the heat of an argument, everything seems urgent, everything seems serious, everything needs to be said RIGHT NOW. But in truth, almost nothing needs to be said right now. Almost everything can wait. And what you say in the heat of the moment is, frequently, what you regret having said the next day.

Ask yourself: "If I say this, how will I feel tomorrow? If I shout, how will I feel tomorrow? If I go quiet, how will I feel tomorrow?" There is no right answer. But the question, in itself, creates emotional distance. And distance is what allows you to choose, instead of react.

Question 5: "Is he my enemy, or is he someone who is also suffering?"

This is the most generous question. And the hardest to ask when you're hurting. Because when you feel attacked, your brain sees the other person as a threat. As an enemy. As someone you need to defend yourself from.

But most of the time, your partner is not your enemy. They are someone who is also wounded. Who is also reacting from old patterns. Who also doesn't know how to get out of the cycle. Who also puts their head on

the pillow at night and thinks: "Why does this always happen?"

When you can see the other as someone who suffers (and not as someone who makes you suffer), the dynamic shifts. Not because you erase yourself. Not because you ignore what you feel. But because you move from the position of adversary to the position of partner. And two partners who suffer together can find a way out. Two adversaries fighting against each other remain trapped.

4. SyncHim bridge

If these questions helped you, if you feel they opened a crack in the repetition, I want you to know: there is more. Not more questions (five is enough). More depth. More understanding about what is happening beneath your couple conflicts. More work on the family patterns each person brings to the relationship.

SyncHim is the space I created for couples who want to go beyond the surface. For those who have realized that communication doesn't resolve everything, that agreements aren't enough, that what repeats comes from deeper than the present. Find it at synchim.viviannedossantos.com.

And if you feel the work begins with you (and it often does), FreeMe may be the starting point: where you look at your patterns, at what you inherited, at what you carry that isn't yours. At freeme.viviannedossantos.com.

But for now, stay with the questions. Write them on a piece of paper. Put them on the bathroom mirror or on the refrigerator door. And the next time the impulse comes, before reacting, try stopping. Try asking.

Just that. With no guarantees it will work the first time. With no promises of perfection. Just the honest attempt to do something different.

Because every time you stop before reacting, even if only once in ten, that's already a victory. And each small victory opens space for the next.

And I want to share something I observe in couples who practice these questions: the effect isn't only individual. It's relational. When one person in the couple changes the way they react (even if the other doesn't know they're doing this exercise), the dynamic shifts. Because the pattern needs two to work. He provokes, you react. Or you provoke, he reacts. If one of the pieces changes position, the whole board reorganizes.

Some women tell me that, after they started using these questions, their partners became confused. "You didn't shout." "You didn't slam the door." "You stayed calm." And that confusion, strange as it may seem, is the beginning of change. Because when the expected doesn't happen, the other person is forced out of their own automatic mode. And in that moment of confusion, in that space where the script failed, something new can happen. A real conversation. A different look. A silence that isn't cold, it's presence.

I don't promise these questions will save your relationship. There are relationships that need much more than five questions. But I can promise you that, if you practice them honestly, you will step out of the repetition. You will stop being the actress who repeats the same role and begin to be someone who chooses. And choice, however imperfect, is always more dignified than an automatic reaction.

And one day, without noticing, the pattern begins to loosen. Not because it disappears. Because you are no longer the same person it controlled.

This guide is a self-knowledge resource about relational dynamics. It does not constitute therapeutic or couples therapy advice. If your relationship involves violence or abuse, seek specialized help.

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